

KB-002-Payment-Issues

KB-002 — Payment & Billing Issues

Category: Payment

Call Volume: ~23% of all support contacts

Trust Impact: HIGH — payment failures are the #1 reason drivers churn from a network

Primary Remote Actions: Session credit flag, billing team escalation, transaction lookup

Why This Matters

Payment issues are disproportionately damaging to driver trust. Among drivers who report a problem, 23% involve payment — and in 19% of those payment cases, the charger accepted payment but the session never started. That means drivers paid for nothing. Even a single such experience can cause a driver to switch networks permanently. Speed of resolution and proactive refund communication are critical.

Background: How Payment Authorization Works

Understanding the payment flow helps agents identify exactly where it broke.

1. **Driver presents payment method** (app wallet, tap credit/debit card, RFID card linked to billing, plug-and-charge certificate)
2. **Pre-authorization hold:** The network places a hold (typically \$25–\$50) on the payment method to confirm it's valid and has sufficient funds
3. **Authorization response:** The payment processor returns APPROVED or DECLINED within a few seconds
4. **Session start signal:** Only on APPROVED does the charger unlock the connector and begin the handshake

5. **Session settles:** At session end (or at billing intervals for long sessions), the actual kWh or time charge is captured; the pre-auth hold is released or adjusted

Failure at steps 2–4 = “charged but no session.”

Failure at step 5 = billing discrepancy.

Section A — Card Declined / Payment Not Going Through

Common Root Causes

Cause	Frequency	Notes
Bank flagged the pre-auth as unusual	~35%	EV charger merchants are often unfamiliar to fraud filters
Card expired or wrong details in app	~20%	Driver may not realize the card on file is outdated
Insufficient funds / credit limit	~15%	Pre-auth amount may exceed available balance
Contactless timeout at reader	~10%	Tap-to-pay fails; chip insert works
Payment processor downtime	~5%	Affects all users on network simultaneously
Corporate card restrictions	~5%	Company cards sometimes block non-travel merchants
3D Secure / additional authentication required	~5%	Card requires bank app confirmation
Virtual card / prepaid card not accepted	~5%	Some networks don't accept prepaid

Diagnostic Script — Card Declined

Step 1 — Identify the payment method

“Are you paying through our app, tapping your card directly on the reader, or using an RFID card?”

If using the app:

“Let me check a couple of things. First, can you open the app and confirm which card is set as your payment method? Sometimes a card expires and the old one stays on file.”

If the card is expired: > “That would explain it — the card on file has expired. You can update it in the app under Payment Settings, and then try starting the session again.”

If the card looks valid: > “Try force-closing the app completely and reopening it, then attempt to start the session again.”

If still failing: > “Everything looks correct on our side, so this is likely a block from your bank — they sometimes flag EV charging transactions as unusual, especially if it’s your first time using this network. I’d suggest calling the number on the back of your card and letting them know you’re trying to use it at an EV charging station. Alternatively, try a different card.”

If tapping the card directly on the reader:

“Contactless payment can time out on EV chargers because the reader waits longer than a typical point-of-sale terminal. Try inserting your chip instead of tapping — that usually works reliably.”

If RFID card:

“Let me check if your RFID card is active on our system... [look up card status]”

- Card active: Try holding it flat against the reader for a full 3 seconds, not a quick tap.
- Card inactive: Reactivate in the backend and confirm with the driver.
- Card unregistered: Link it to their account. See KB-007.

Step 2 — Check for network-wide payment processor issue

If multiple drivers are reporting payment failures in a short window, check the payment processor status dashboard. If it’s a processor outage:

“I can see there’s a temporary issue with our payment system that’s affecting multiple drivers right now — it’s not specific to your card. Our team is working on it. I’m sorry for the timing. Would it help if I noted your details so we can reach out when it’s resolved?”

Step 3 — If all else fails

“I want to make sure you can charge today. A few options: try a different card if you have one, try the app if you were using a physical card, or check if this station accepts QR code or guest checkout. I know this is frustrating and I’m sorry.”

Section B — Charged But Session Never Started

This is the most trust-damaging payment scenario. The driver’s payment was captured or pre-authorized, but the session never delivered energy.

How to Identify

- Driver says they were charged (or saw a hold) but the charger never started
- Session log shows an authorization but no energy delivery
- Driver has a receipt or bank notification but the car is still at the same battery level

Agent Script

“I’m really sorry — you absolutely should not be charged for a session that didn’t run. Let me pull up that transaction right now.”

Step 1 — Locate the transaction

Look up by: account/email, card last 4 digits, approximate timestamp, station ID.

Step 2 — Confirm what the system shows

System shows	Agent action
Pre-auth hold (not settled)	“The charge on your bank statement is a pre-authorization hold — it will automatically drop off within 3 to 5 business days without any action from us. No actual charge was captured.”
Settled charge with \$0 kWh	“You’re right — a charge was captured but no energy was delivered. I’m flagging this for a full refund right now.”
No transaction found	“I don’t see a matching transaction. Can you share the last 4 digits of the card and the approximate time?”

Step 3 — Flag for refund

“I’ve flagged this for our billing team. You should see a full refund within 3 to 5 business days. Can I confirm which email address to send your confirmation to?”

Log: station ID, transaction ID, charge amount, timestamp, driver email, session outcome (no energy delivered).

Important: Do not tell the driver a specific refund date beyond the 3–5 business day window. Refund timelines depend on their bank.

Step 4 — Attempt to get them charging today

“While that gets sorted — do you want to try starting a new session? I can try a remote reset on the station first to make sure it’s ready.”

Section C — Billed Wrong Amount

Driver was charged more than expected

Step 1 — Explain the pricing model

“Happy to walk you through it. At this station, the rate is [per-kWh rate / per-minute rate / flat session fee]. The total for your session would be based on [X kWh delivered / Y minutes].”

Confirm the rate shown matches the posted rate at the station and in the app.

Step 2 — Common discrepancies

Driver complaint	Likely explanation	Script
“I was charged more than the posted rate”	Rate may have changed, or driver used peak pricing period	“Let me check the rate schedule for that station — some locations have different rates at different times of day.”
“I was charged for time I wasn’t there”	Session may not have been ended properly	“It’s possible the session kept running. Always tap End Session in the app or on the screen — if the cable is unplugged without ending the session, the timer may keep running in some systems.”
“I was charged twice”	Could be pre-auth + final charge appearing simultaneously	“What you may be seeing is a temporary pre-authorization hold and the final charge appearing at the same time. They don’t add up — one will drop off. If both settle, contact us and we’ll refund one immediately.”

Driver complaint	Likely explanation	Script
"I was charged an idle fee"	Driver left vehicle plugged in after session ended	"Our stations charge an idle fee of [X cents/minute] when a vehicle remains plugged in after the session completes to keep the spot available for other drivers. This is shown in the app and on the station screen before the session starts."

Step 3 — Billing dispute escalation

"I can't adjust your bill directly, but I'm flagging this for our billing team with all the details. They'll review the session data and reach out within [1–2 business days]. Would email or phone be better for you?"

Disputes over \$50 or involving fraud claims go to Tier 2 immediately.

Section D — Pricing Confusion (Pre-Call)

Drivers often call to understand pricing before they charge. This is a service opportunity — a clear, confident explanation prevents a billing dispute call later.

Rate Types and How to Explain Them

Per-kWh pricing (most consumer-friendly, mirrors a utility bill): > "You pay for the actual energy your car receives, measured in kilowatt-hours — the same unit on your electricity bill at home. The rate at this station is [X cents per kWh]."

Per-minute pricing (common on older networks): > "You pay for the time you're plugged in, not the energy itself. The rate is [X cents per minute]. If your car charges at full speed, this works out to roughly [calculated cost per kWh equivalent] per kilowatt-hour."

Session fee / flat rate: > "This station charges a flat fee of [X dollars] per session, regardless of how long you charge or how much energy you receive. It's simple but less cost-effective for short sessions."

Idle fees: > "Once your session completes, if you leave your car plugged in, an idle fee of [X cents per minute] kicks in. You'll get a notification in the app before it starts."

Membership vs. guest pricing: > “If you’re not a member of our network, the guest rate is [X]. Members pay [Y]. Membership costs [Z per month] — if you charge regularly, it usually pays for itself within [estimated sessions].”

Escalation Criteria

Condition	Action
Charged but session never started	Flag for billing review; offer refund timeline
Billing dispute over \$50	Escalate to Tier 2
Driver reports unauthorized charges / fraud	Escalate to Tier 2 immediately; advise driver to contact their bank
Payment processor down (multiple affected)	Notify Tier 2; update status page
Driver threatens chargeback	Do not push back — acknowledge, escalate to Tier 2

Agent Reminders

- Never promise a refund will appear “today” or “immediately” — banks have their own processing timelines.
- Always confirm the driver’s email before closing — the refund confirmation is evidence they’ll need.
- Pre-auth holds look like charges to drivers. Calmly explain the difference before they call their bank.
- An idle fee complaint is almost never a billing error — but acknowledge the frustration before explaining.
- If a driver says they’ll dispute the charge with their bank, treat this as urgent — escalate to Tier 2 and log it as a potential chargeback.